How to Read This Book

The first part of this book makes sure you're ready. By the time you're done with it, you'll have been introduced to Ruby (the language), you'll have been exposed to an overview of Rails, you'll have Ruby and Rails installed, and you'll have verified the installation with a simple example.

The next part takes you through the concepts behind Rails via an extended example: we build a simple online store. It doesn't take you one by one through each component of Rails (such as "here's a chapter on models, here's a chapter on views," and so forth). These components are designed to work together, and each chapter in this section tackles a specific set of related tasks that involve a number of these components working together.

Most folks seem to enjoy building the application along with the book. If you don't want to do all that typing, you can cheat and download the source code (a compressed tar archive[10] or a zip file).[11]

Be careful if you ever choose to copy files directly from the download into your application: if the timestamps on the files are old, the server won't know that it needs to pick up these changes. You can update the timestamps using the `touch` command on either MacOS or Linux, or you can edit the file and save it. Alternatively, you can restart your Rails server.

Part 3, *Rails in Depth*, surveys the entire Rails ecosystem. This starts with the functions and facilities of Rails that you'll now be familiar with. It then covers a number of key dependencies that the Rails framework makes use of that contribute directly to the overall functionality that the Rails framework delivers. Finally, we survey a number of popular plugins that augment the Rails framework and make Rails an open ecosystem rather than merely a framework.

Along the way, you'll see various conventions we've adopted: